

The 2026 Public-Sector Revenue Opportunity Playbook

A source-backed guide to agencies, funded buyers, recipients, primes, partners, and practical next actions.

\$179B FY2025 prime federal contracts reported to small businesses	~\$273B FY2025 prime plus subcontract awards reported to small businesses	7 steps From company context to an owned next action
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Built for founders and revenue teams that need credible targets, clear revenue motions, contact paths, and next actions - not a generic list of grants or contracts.

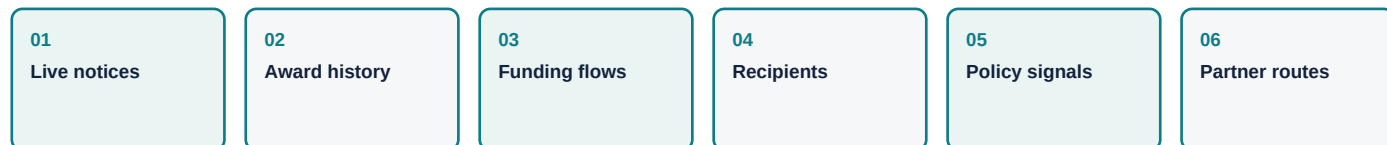
Opportunity Scanner by Opportunity Systems

Research current as of July 27, 2026. Always recheck time-sensitive official sources before acting.

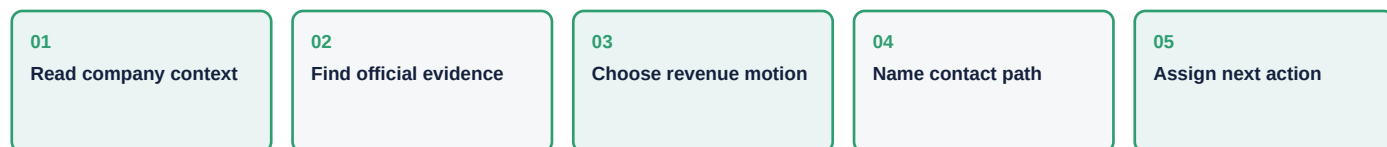
The opportunity landscape

Use these lanes to separate records that imply different buyers, partners, timing, and next actions.

6 evidence lanes to investigate



From signal to an owned revenue action



These diagrams are operating maps, not a promise that every lane is open. The report explains the evidence, constraints, and qualification checks behind each route.

Updated July 27, 2026.

Offer and audience

This guide is for founders, revenue leaders, partnerships teams, agencies, and commercial companies deciding whether public-sector money creates a realistic growth path for what they already sell.

Conversion promise: Learn a repeatable method for turning official public records into qualified targets, revenue motions, contact paths, and next actions. The guide does not promise eligibility, awards, contracts, customers, or revenue.

Executive brief

Public-sector opportunity research is often reduced to searching for an open contract or grant. That misses much of the useful market evidence. Official records can show an agency preparing to buy, a prior contractor delivering adjacent work, a nonprofit or institution that received funding, a program likely to create future recipients, or a policy change that may alter demand.

The market is meaningful, but broad totals are not a company's addressable opportunity. The Small Business Administration reported that in fiscal year 2025 nearly 28 percent of prime federal contract dollars, about \$179 billion, went to small businesses. Including prime contracts and subcontracts, SBA reported nearly \$273 billion awarded to small businesses. Those figures describe federal contracting performance, not all government spending and not the opportunity available to any one company.

A useful opportunity row preserves the source, names the target and revenue motion, recommends a credible contact path, and assigns an action that reduces uncertainty.

The operating unit is a decision-ready signal: one official record, one interpretation, one target, one revenue motion, and one owned next action. If an element is missing, the record remains research rather than pipeline.

State of the channel

Trend 1: Small businesses remain material participants in federal contracting

SBA's FY2025 scorecard release reported nearly \$179 billion in prime federal contracts to small businesses and nearly \$273 billion when prime and subcontract awards are combined.

Business implication: A small or midsize company should not reject the channel solely because it assumes every award goes to a large incumbent.

Recommended action: Identify the agencies and prime contractors already buying adjacent products or services, then qualify direct and subcontracting paths separately.

Trend 2: The useful record appears before and after the open bid

SAM.gov contains pre-solicitation, solicitation, award, and sole-source notices. Acquisition.gov links to recurring agency procurement forecasts. USAspending shows recipients and award history. Grants.gov distinguishes forecasted, posted, closed, and archived opportunities.

Business implication: A solicitation is only one stage of market evidence. Historical awards, forecasts, recipients, and pre-solicitation notices support different decisions.

Recommended action: Label every record by status before assigning a sales action. Never call an award notice an open bid or a forecast guaranteed funding.

Trend 3: Indirect routes often create the more realistic first move

SBA distinguishes prime contractors that work directly with government from subcontractors that work for other contractors. Grants and assistance awards can also create funded recipients that later buy products, services, implementation support, or partnerships.

Business implication: The best first motion may be Sell to Funded Buyer, Sell to Award Recipient, Partner with Recipient, or Channel / Distributor Motion rather than Direct Apply or a direct agency bid.

Recommended action: Compare direct and indirect routes for the same signal, then choose the one that fits the company's readiness and offer.

Trend 4: Source volume increases the need for qualification

Official systems answer different questions and use different definitions. Award, obligation, outlay, recipient, notice, program, and forecast should not be combined as if they measure the same thing.

Business implication: More records can create more noise unless source type, time status, relevance, and next action are normalized.

Recommended action: Require every surfaced signal to pass the qualification test below before it enters a CRM or workflow.

Source and action map

Start with the business question, then select the source. Searching every portal for the same phrase usually creates duplicate noise.

Business question	Primary official source	What to capture	Best first action	Do not infer
What might an agency buy next?	Agency procurement forecast; SAM.gov pre-solicitation or sources-sought notice	Agency, office, category, estimated timing, notice type, response instruction	Validate fit; respond to market research when appropriate; watch for solicitation	Forecasted work will occur, or that a response is a bid
What can we bid now?	SAM.gov solicitation and amendments	Notice ID, due date and time zone, set-aside, NAICS, place of performance, contact, amendment status	Run a bid/no-bid review and confirm registration readiness	The original notice remains current after amendments
Who has bought adjacent work?	USAspending contract awards; SAM.gov award notices	Awarding office, recipient, award type, description, action date, period of performance	Research incumbent, vehicle, recomplete timing, and subcontract route	A historical award is open or will recur unchanged
Who received program money?	USAspending assistance awards; agency recipient data	Recipient, program, award type, amount definition, project period, geography	Validate funded activity and identify buyer or partner roles	Recipient has uncommitted funds or current purchase intent
Can we apply for assistance?	Grants.gov posted opportunity and agency instructions	Eligibility, funding instrument, deadline, cost share, allowable activities, attachments	Complete an eligibility and capacity screen before writing	A for-profit company is eligible because the topic fits
What rule may change demand?	Federal Register and agency rulemaking page	Proposed/final status, comment or effective date, affected entities, docket	Assign policy owner; assess operational impact; comment when relevant	A proposal is final or an announcement creates a purchase
Who can help us enter?	SBA subcontracting guidance, agency small-business office, prime award data	Prime, vehicle, category, subcontracting or supplier route	Prepare a specific partner hypothesis and capability proof	A prime needs another generic vendor introduction

For state and local work, use the jurisdiction's official procurement, grants, budget, and legislative sources. Federal portals do not provide a complete picture of state and local opportunities, and portal labels are not automatically comparable across jurisdictions.

The seven-step opportunity method

Step 1: Translate the company, not just its keywords

Start with the company's products, services, customers, outcomes, delivery model, geography, and constraints. Translate commercial language into public-sector mission problems, procurement categories, program terminology, and likely buyer types. A music network might map to creative workforce, city events, arts education, tourism, and parks programming. A DME supplier might map to VA procurement, rehabilitation, prosthetics, funded providers, reimbursement, and channel partners.

Output: a short company profile, five to ten source-search concepts, and a "not a fit" list that prevents generic words from overwhelming the scan.

Step 2: Search by source purpose

Use SAM.gov for federal procurement notices and stage. Use USAspending for federal award and recipient evidence. Use Grants.gov for federal assistance opportunities and status. Use Federal Register for rules, notices, and policy demand. Use agency forecasts and official state or local portals for earlier demand and non-federal activity.

Use a broad discovery pass to learn agency language, then a verification pass to capture the official record's identifier, status, dates, organization, amendments, and direct URL.

Output: records grouped by what each source can prove, with duplicates linked rather than counted separately.

Step 3: Separate live opportunity from market evidence

Assign one status: active opportunity, historical market evidence, policy signal, source route, or research only. Verify dates, notice type, amendments, eligibility, and whether the record is still current.

Use the status that drives behavior:

- **Active opportunity:** a currently actionable solicitation or posted assistance notice, subject to eligibility and deadline checks.
- **Early demand signal:** a forecast, sources-sought notice, request for information, or pre-solicitation record.
- **Historical market evidence:** an award, prior solicitation, archived grant, or past recipient record.
- **Policy signal:** a proposed rule, final rule, notice, guidance change, or program announcement.
- **Route evidence:** a schedule, vendor portal, contract vehicle, small-business office, or official partner pathway.
- **Research only:** relevant context without a supported target or action.

Output: a defensible source-status label, time-sensitivity level, and one-sentence limitation.

Step 4: Name the target

Identify who controls money, purchasing, implementation, or access. The target may be an agency, procurement office, program office, funded buyer, award recipient, prime vendor, distributor, grantee, channel partner, or policy owner.

Separate three roles when possible: the **economic buyer** controls budget, the **program owner** defines the need, and the **access point** controls the purchasing or partnership route. They may sit in different organizations.

Output: one primary target organization and buyer/partner type, plus the program owner or access point when distinct.

Step 5: Choose the revenue motion

Use the motion that matches the evidence: Direct Apply, Sell to Agency, Sell to Funded Buyer, Sell to Award Recipient, Partner with Recipient, Channel / Distributor Motion, Monitor Policy, or Research Only.

Use **Direct Apply** only with supported eligibility, recipient motions only with a plausible funded need, and **Channel / Distributor Motion** when an existing vehicle or contract holder makes indirect access more credible.

Output: one primary motion plus a short reason alternatives were rejected.

Step 6: Build the contact path

Start with source-native contacts, procurement offices, program offices, vendor registration, recipient leadership, prime contractors, or official portals. Personal email enrichment is optional and should not replace a better official route.

Use this contact-path ladder, stopping at the first route that fits the record:

1. Follow the response or application instructions in the official notice.
2. Use the named contracting, grants-management, or program contact for a relevant procedural question.
3. Use the agency vendor portal, forecast contact, small-business office, industry liaison, or program office.
4. For recipient-led motions, use the recipient's procurement page, program leadership, operations lead, or partnership route.

5. For channels, identify the contract holder, distributor category owner, supplier-diversity team, or subcontract manager and lead with a specific gap hypothesis.
6. Use person-level enrichment only after the organization, role, and reason for contact are supported.

The opening message should cite the source and ask a bounded question. "We saw your award" is weak. "Your published project description includes regional employer training; we support provider coordination and want to confirm whether implementation partners are selected locally" gives the recipient something concrete to answer.

Output: a primary route, fallback route, recommended role, outreach premise, and manual research instruction when a named person is not yet supported.

Step 7: Assign the next best action

The action should reduce the largest uncertainty. Examples include validating an amendment, checking eligibility, registering in a vendor portal, researching the incumbent prime, confirming a recipient's program scope, or assigning a CRM task with the source attached.

Match the task to the largest uncertainty: timing, scope fit, access route, or readiness. "Contact agency" is incomplete; specify the role, question, due date, and expected answer.

Output: one owned task with evidence, due date, and follow-up state.

Fifteen-minute triage protocol

Use this before deeper research. It keeps attractive but unusable records from consuming the week.

Minutes 0-3: authenticate. Confirm official domain, identifier, record type, updated date, amendments, and instructions.

Minutes 4-7: test fit. Find the exact scope language that maps to the offer; downgrade broad keyword matches.

Minutes 8-10: test access. Check timing, eligibility or set-aside, geography, vehicle, registration, and the largest readiness gap.

Minutes 11-15: decide. Name target, motion, and contact route, then mark **pursue**, **validate**, **monitor**, or **reject** with a reason code.

Qualification scorecard

Score each dimension High, Medium, or Low rather than inventing false precision:

Dimension	Question	Reject or downgrade when
Offer fit	Does the record map to what the company actually sells?	The connection depends on generic words rather than a use case.
Source confidence	Is the source official and does it support the claim?	The record is secondary, incomplete, or misread.
Timing	Is it active, forecasted, recent, historical, or expired?	Timing is unknown or the deadline has passed.
Target clarity	Can the agency, recipient, prime, or partner be named?	No plausible organization controls the next step.
Motion clarity	Is there a realistic way to sell, apply, partner, or monitor?	The motion assumes eligibility or access without evidence.
Contact path	Is there a credible office, portal, role, or research route?	Outreach would be random or inappropriate.
Next action	Can one task reduce uncertainty now?	The only action is vague additional research.

High Actionability requires strong fit, credible evidence, a named target, and a concrete next action. Medium Actionability needs validation. Low Actionability remains market context or is screened out.

Add four hard gates after the scorecard:

Gate	Pass condition	If it fails
Truth gate	The source supports the row's plain-language claim	Correct the claim or reject the row

Gate	Pass condition	If it fails
Access gate	A legitimate application, procurement, partner, or monitoring route exists	Keep as market evidence, not pipeline
Capacity gate	The company can plausibly deliver within scope, geography, timing, and compliance constraints	Seek a partner or decline
Economics gate	The likely effort and route justify further diligence	Set a research cap or reject

The economics gate uses known effort drivers such as proposal burden, registrations, inventory, cost share, partner margin, and delivery capacity rather than an invented win probability.

Worked illustrative example

Company context: A workforce-training platform serves employers and training providers.

Source signal: An official Department of Labor award record shows a regional workforce intermediary received funding for sector-based training.

Qualification: The award is historical money-flow evidence, not an open application. The program purpose fits the platform's employer and provider workflow.

Target: The funded intermediary and participating training providers.

Revenue motion: Sell to Funded Buyer or Partner with Recipient.

Contact path: Program director, employer partnerships lead, procurement route, or implementation partner listed by the recipient.

Next action: Confirm the active project period and implementation model, then prepare a source-backed partnership note. This example is illustrative and is not a customer result or claim that the recipient is currently buying.

30-day operating plan

Period	Work	Deliverable	Review question
Days 1-3	Build company translation, exclusions, readiness inventory, and two priority motions	One-page opportunity profile	Are we searching for things we can actually sell or deliver?
Days 4-7	Search one demand source, one award source, one assistance source, and one policy/forecast source	20-30 authenticated records with source type and dates	Did we preserve what each record proves?
Days 8-12	Run fifteen-minute triage; deduplicate related records; apply rejection codes	Shortlist of 10-15 signals	Which search terms created noise?
Days 13-17	Complete target, motion, contact path, limitation, and readiness gap for each shortlist row	Five decision-ready opportunity rows	Can a new teammate understand why each row matters?
Days 18-22	Execute bounded validation: questions, portal checks, incumbent research, or recipient-scope confirmation	Evidence attached to each validation task	Did the answer change the motion or actionability?
Days 23-26	Move qualified rows to CRM or workflow; prepare source-led outreach or bid/apply decisions	Owners, due dates, follow-up states	Is every task specific enough to close?
Days 27-30	Review outcomes and query performance; archive stale records; schedule rechecks	Mini retrospective and next scan brief	What should be searched, stopped, or monitored next month?

Measure evidence completeness, rejection reasons, and validation outcomes before drawing conclusions from early revenue metrics.

Limits and responsible use

- Public records can lag, change, or omit context. Recheck the official source before acting.
- An award or recipient is not proof of current buying intent.
- A forecast is not a solicitation or guarantee that an acquisition will occur.
- A grant program is not necessarily open, and a company may not be eligible.
- Federal totals do not represent state and local spending or a company's addressable market.
- Contact information in a source may be intended for program or procurement questions, not sales outreach.
- Opportunity Scanner supports research and workflow decisions; it does not provide legal, accounting, grant-writing, procurement, or eligibility advice.

Next-action checklist

- Define the company's public-sector use cases.
- Select official sources by the question they answer.
- Verify status and dates.
- Name the target organization.
- Select one revenue motion.
- Choose an official or role-based contact path.
- Assign one next action.
- Preserve the source in the workflow.
- Record rejection reasons as well as pursued rows.
- Recheck live records before outreach, application, or bid activity.
- State what the source does not prove.
- Close or refresh records whose dates or status have changed.

Evidence and source ledger

Claim or use	Official source	Retrieval date	Caveat
FY2025 small-business federal contracting figures	SBA, official source	2026-07-10	Federal contracting only; not all government spending or company opportunity size.
Annual scorecard purpose and 23 percent aggregate goal	SBA, official source	2026-07-10	Agency goals and results differ.
Prime and subcontractor distinction	SBA, official source	2026-07-10	Participation path, not proof of available work.
Procurement notice types	SAM.gov, official source	2026-07-10	Notice type and status must be checked.
Recipient definition and award research	USAspending, official source	2026-07-10	Recipient does not automatically mean buyer.
Grant opportunity statuses	Grants.gov, official source	2026-07-10	A forecast is not guaranteed to become an announcement.
Agency procurement forecast directory	Acquisition.gov, official source	2026-07-10	Planning signal, not a solicitation or award.
Award definition and distinction from payment	USAspending, official source	2026-07-11	Awards include multiple assistance and contract types; inspect the record.
Forecast limitation	Grants.gov, official source	2026-07-11	Grants.gov states a forecast is planned and is not guaranteed to become an FOA.
Federal rules, proposed rules, and notices	Federal Register, official source	2026-07-11	Verify document type, dates, agency, and whether a rule is proposed or final.

Put this guide to work

Opportunity Scanner reads your company website, finds source-backed public-sector signals, and translates them into target organizations, revenue motions, contact paths, and next actions.

Run a free company scan at opportunityscanner.ai

Recheck official sources before any outreach, application, registration, or bid decision.